

The IBD Trigger Tracker

A structured way to find out what could be making your symptoms worse

"It feels worse after X" is a hunch until it's written down next to what actually happened on the days it didn't. A trigger is rarely one thing — food, stress, sleep, medication timing and things outside your control all play a part, and the only way to tell them apart is a record you can compare across weeks, not a memory of last Tuesday.

FOUR CATEGORIES

What to Track

Category	Why it matters
Food & drink	The most commonly suspected trigger, and the easiest to test one item at a time.[1]
Stress & sleep	Both are independently linked to symptom flares in IBD, not just "in your head." [2][3]
Medication	Missed doses, timing, and any new NSAID or antibiotic course all matter.
Other	Infections, travel, menstrual cycle and weather changes all get mentioned often enough to be worth a note.

You don't need to log everything perfectly — a rushed one-line note beats a perfect entry you never finish. Consistency over a few weeks matters far more than detail on any single day.

FILL THIS IN AS YOU GO

The Weekly Log

Day	Symptoms (0-10) & bowel pattern	Food / drink notes	Stress, sleep, meds, other
Mon			
Tue			
Wed			
Thu			
Fri			
Sat			
Sun			

Photocopy this page, print another, or use the Health Record on VanceHealthHub to keep the same four columns in one private digital place instead.

AFTER A FEW WEEKS

Reading the Pattern

- Look for repeats, not one-offs — the same food or situation, the same reaction, three separate times is worth raising
- Compare good weeks to bad weeks side by side, not just bad days in isolation
- A trigger doesn't have to act the same day — some patterns show up 24-48 hours later
- If nothing repeats after a few weeks, that's useful too: it points away from a single trigger and toward discussing the pattern with your team

DON'T SELF-DIAGNOSE FROM IT

When to Bring It to Your Team

This is a starting point, not a diagnosis

A tracker tells you what's worth asking about — it can't tell you whether something is a genuine trigger, a coincidence, or a sign of something else entirely. Bring the pattern to your IBD team or dietitian rather than acting on it alone, especially before cutting out foods or medication.

GO FURTHER

More Support From VanceHealthHub

- **Health Record** — log symptoms, bowel pattern and dates in one private place
- **The Practical Food Guide for Crohn's & Colitis** — trigger foods in more depth, and when to see a dietitian
- **Malnutrition Calculator** — track unintentional weight change to raise with a dietitian or GP
- **VANCE-Ai** — a starting point for questions between appointments, not a substitute for your care team

None of these replace your GP, gastroenterologist or dietitian, and nothing on VanceHealthHub should be used to diagnose or treat a condition.

THE PRINCIPLES BEHIND IT

References

Crohn's & Colitis UK · Guts UK

1. Crohn's & Colitis UK. Food and IBD, 2023.
2. Bernstein CN. Psychological Stress and Depression: Risk Factors for IBD? Dig Dis, 2016;34(1-2):58-63.
3. Ali T, et al. Sleep, immunity and inflammation in gastrointestinal disorders. World J Gastroenterol, 2013;19(48):9231-9239.
4. Bischoff SC, et al. ESPEN guideline on Clinical Nutrition in inflammatory bowel disease. Clin Nutr, 2023;42(3):352-379.

Medical disclaimer: general information only, not a substitute for advice from your own healthcare team. If you think you may have a medical emergency, call 999 or NHS 111.